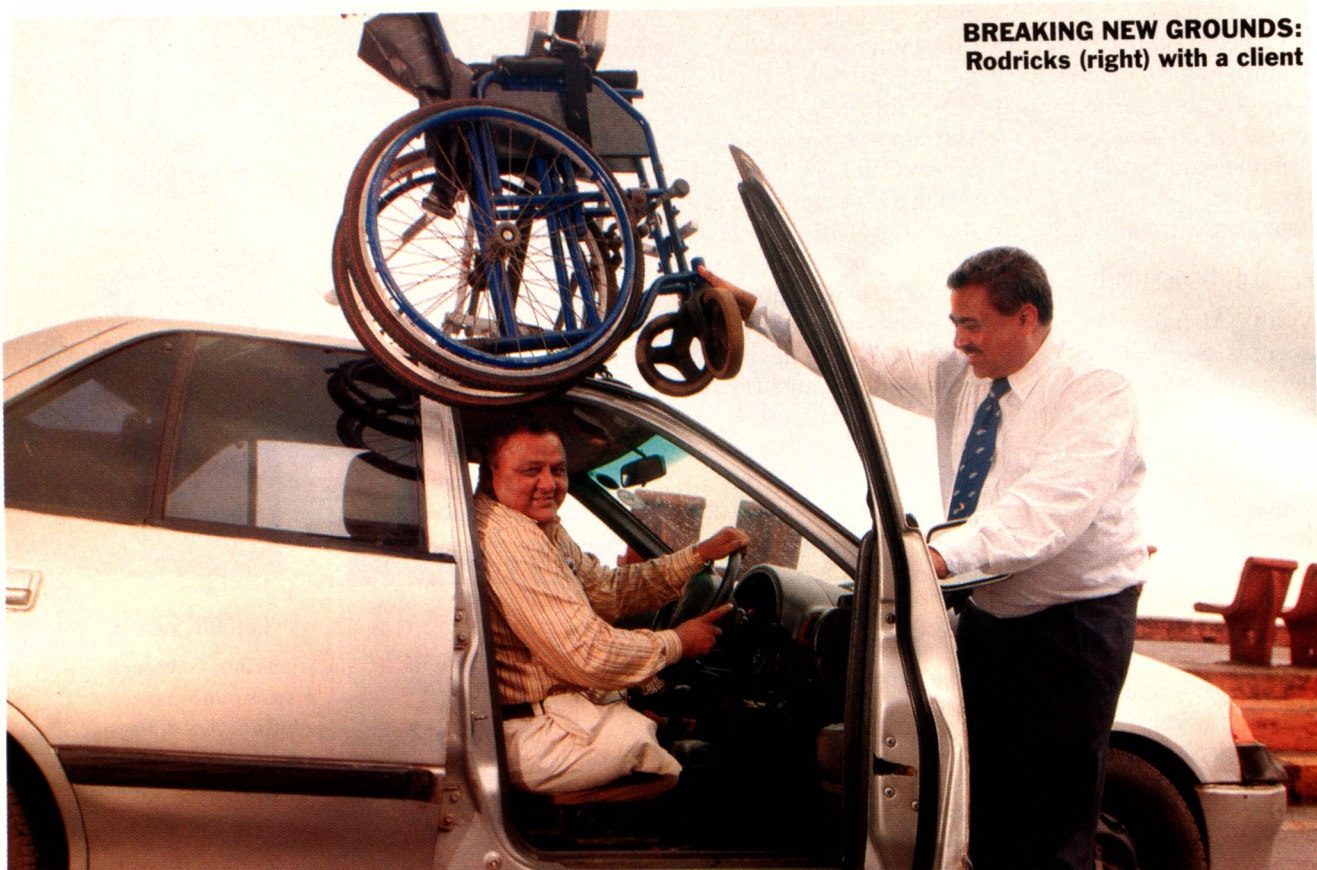




BREAKING NEW GROUNDS:
Rodricks (right) with a client

Enabling a Smooth Ride

An automobile engineer makes a career out of his hobby: designing cars for physically challenged

■ **By Prerana Thakurdesai**

It is largely believed that friendship and business do not go hand-in-hand. Not so for Ferdinand Rodricks. Designing vehicles for the physically challenged is, to him, not just good business sense, but also a chance of forging friendships. He has been remodelling vehicles for these people for the past 20 years now and has had at least 1,000 clients. That he remembers each one by his name is testimony to the bond he has been able to strike with them.

What started as a hobby for the automobile engineer when he remodelled a friend's Fiat in 1984 has now taken the shape of an alternative profession. He has now set up a vehicle remodelling workshop along with his garage under the brand name of Ferro Equip. Not only this, he hosts parties for all his clients and has also developed a website www.handicappedpeople.com which contains all the information that a disabled person may need for his vehicle and details of Rodericks's own work.

Sanjay Joshi, a businessman from Borivli, Mumbai, lost both his legs in a railway accident in 1990. He approached 'Ferdie', as he is popularly known, in 1999. "I didn't know



how to drive a car. But I wanted him to remodel a Gypsy for me and he did it," he says. He now drives a Maruti Esteem, remodelled again by Rodricks. Although the car hasn't troubled him ever, Joshi has kept in touch with its designer. "It's only because Ferdie is not in a corporate profession that he has the warmth. I still do not know why he does so much for the handicapped," he adds.

So how does he make it all work? After years of experiments, Rodricks has invented some set designs for different kinds of disabilities that work for anyone. It takes him around three days to reshape a vehicle, which includes fitting in parallel controls. He doesn't play with the engine or the chassis but just provides alternative hand-operated brakes, accelerators and smaller devices. "I try and keep all the requirements in mind but I also discreetly slow down the car's speed without telling the clients," laughs Rodricks. He also consults the client's therapist before re-designing a vehicle. The price for this service varies from Rs 8,000-40,000 per car.

What's next on cards? He says a small Formula 1 circuit replica which underprivileged children will get to play with. With men like these, who needs angels?